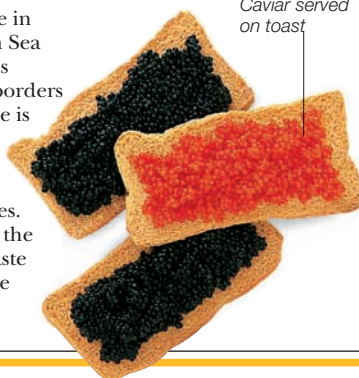




CAVIAR

The largest inland lake in the world, the Caspian Sea covers 146,111 sq miles (378,400 sq km) and borders five countries. The lake is home to a variety of fish, such as sturgeon, from which a type of caviar (fish eggs) comes. However, pollution of the waters by industrial waste has led to a drop in the numbers of fish.



ISLAM

Throughout central Asia, Islam is the main religion. It arrived in the region in the early 8th century. While central Asia was part of the Soviet Union, Islam was suppressed. Traditional Muslim wedding ceremonies were forbidden. Throughout this time, however, people continued to worship in secret. With the end of communism, Islam has gained strength in every country.

